

Task 4 — Medical Claims Audit: every hit, with proposed rewrites

Scanned: all 13 lesson tracks in lessons.json (the 11 originals plus Supporting Someone and Anger & Control) and stories.json, for: research shows, studies, dopamine, rewires, dependency pathways, clinically, proven, neuroscience, neural, brain chemistry, cortisol, demonstrated-in-a-lab, and similar.

Result: 190 hits. 128 rewrites proposed, 62 keeps. stories.json: zero hits (the one PAWS mention is a peer voice describing their own experience, which is the format we are moving TO).

Keep categories: VERB = "research" as a verb ("research a meeting near you") — an instruction, not a claim. ENGLISH = ordinary uses of proven/demonstrated. SAFETY = clinical referral language (eating-disorder triage, naloxone, medication-assisted treatment pointers, crisis referrals) — softening these would harm people, and pointing at professional care is protection, not liability. FACT = verifiable public record (WHO classification, reported journalism about platforms/food industry) — facts about others, not medical claims by us.

PROPOSED REWRITES (128)

Porn & Sex

#0 — Day 1 (title)

OLD: Understanding the Dopamine Loop

NEW: Understanding the Loop

#1 — Day 1 (content)

OLD: Every time you acted out, your brain released a hit of dopamine, the chemical tied to anticipation and reward.

NEW: Every time you acted out, you got a hit — the buzz your body serves up for chasing a reward.

#2 — Day 1 (content)

OLD: It's a well-worn neural pathway, built one repetition at a time, and pathways that get built can be rebuilt.

NEW: It's a groove worn deep by repetition — and anything worn in can be worn back out.

#3 — Day 1 (content)

OLD: Here's what's actually happening: dopamine spikes on anticipation, not the act itself.

NEW: Here's the tell: the buzz peaks in the chase — the searching, the anticipating — not the act itself.

#4 — Day 1 (content)

OLD: You don't need to understand neuroscience to recover.

NEW: You don't need a science degree to recover.

#5 — Day 3 (content)

OLD: Research on behavior change consistently shows that accountability with even a single trusted person dramatically increases the odds of sustained change, because it breaks the isolation that shame depends on.

NEW: Ask anyone whose quit finally held: one person who knows the whole truth changes everything, because this thing feeds on secrecy and starves in the open.

#6 — Day 4 (content)

OLD: Urges are not moral failures; they're neurological weather.

NEW: Urges are not moral failures; they're weather. They roll in, they peak, they pass.

#8 — Day 14 (content)

OLD: Research consistently shows that self-compassion after a setback predicts faster return to healthy behavior than self-criticism does.

NEW: The men who get back up fastest after a slip are the ones who skip the self-hatred. Beating yourself up feels like accountability — it's actually the express lane back to acting out.

#10 — Day 27 (content)

OLD: Every well-established recovery model — from twelve-step programs to modern clinical approaches — includes community as a core, non-negotiable component, not an optional add-on.

NEW: Every recovery path that has stood the test of time — the twelve-step rooms, the modern programs, all of them — puts other people at the center. None of them treat community as optional.

#11 — Day 28 (content)

OLD: The second is identity, rooted in something you actually care about, and identity-based motivation tends to outlast rule-based motivation by a wide margin, across almost every area of behavior change research.

NEW: The second is identity, rooted in something you actually care about — and identity outlasts rules. A rule can be argued with at 2am. Who you've decided you are can't.

#12 — Day 30 (content)

OLD: Recovery from a compulsive pattern like this typically unfolds over months and years, not weeks — brain pathways that took a long time to form take real time to rewire, and that's not a discouraging fact, it's simply an accurate one.

NEW: Recovery from a pattern like this unfolds over months and years, not weeks — a groove that took decades to carve takes real time to fill in, and that's not discouraging, it's just accurate.

Alcohol

#13 — Day 3 (content)

OLD: It's neurochemistry finding a new equilibrium, and it does resolve, usually significantly within a week or two even for difficult cases.

NEW: It's your body finding its feet again, and it does settle — for most people, noticeably within a week or two.

#16 — Day 9 (content)

OLD: The problem is what happens after: alcohol disrupts the same neurotransmitter systems that regulate anxiety, so as it wears off, many people experience rebound anxiety often worse than what they started with.

NEW: The problem is what happens after: as the drink wears off, the anxiety it quieted comes back louder than it started. Anyone who's been awake at 4am after a night of drinking knows 'hangxiety' by heart.

#17 — Day 11 (content)

OLD: Alcohol use disorder has a real genetic component — research consistently shows that having a parent or close family member with alcohol dependency significantly increases your own risk, independent of upbringing or environment alone.

NEW: This runs in families — if your father, mother, or someone close fought the bottle, you likely started closer to the edge than other people do. That's not your imagination, and it was never your fault.

#18 — Day 14 (content)

OLD: Alcohol use disorder isn't about a personal shortfall in self-control compared to people who drink without difficulty — it's a real, diagnosable condition shaped by genetics, brain chemistry, environment, and psychological factors, most of which were never fully within your control to begin with.

NEW: Alcohol use disorder isn't a personal shortfall in self-control compared to people who drink without difficulty — it's a real condition that doctors diagnose and treat, shaped by family history, environment, and what you've lived through, most of which was never within your control to begin with.

#19 — Day 22 (content)

OLD: This pattern is well documented in addiction research and has a name: the abstinence violation effect.

NEW: This pattern is so common that recovery rooms have a name for it: the 'screw it' spiral — one slip becomes a lost week because the day already felt ruined.

#23 — Day 28 (content)

OLD: The second is identity, rooted in something you genuinely care about, and identity-based motivation tends to outlast rule-based motivation by a significant margin across behavior change research.

NEW: The second is identity, rooted in something you genuinely care about — and identity outlasts rules. A rule can be argued with at midnight. Who you've decided you are can't.

Smoking

#24 — Day 1 (content)

OLD: Over time, your brain doesn't just want nicotine occasionally — it comes to expect it as part of its normal baseline functioning, which is why quitting affects mood, focus, and energy for a while, not because you're weak, but because your brain chemistry genuinely adjusted around a substance that was arriving constantly.

NEW: Over time, your body stops treating nicotine as an extra and starts treating it as the baseline — which is why quitting hits your mood, focus, and energy for a while. Not because you're weak, but because you're taking back ground a constant supply had claimed.

#25 — Day 1 (content)

OLD: Naming that clearly isn't an excuse — it's context that lets you approach quitting with the right tools instead of blaming your character for a genuinely difficult neurochemical fight.

NEW: Naming that clearly isn't an excuse — it's context that lets you approach quitting with the right tools instead of blaming your character for a genuinely hard physical fight.

#26 — Day 13 (content)

OLD: Nicotine does suppress appetite somewhat and slightly increases metabolism, so some weight gain after quitting is common — research suggests an average of a few pounds for many people, though this varies significantly by individual.

NEW: Nicotine does blunt appetite a little, so some weight gain after quitting is common — most people who've quit will tell you a few pounds came with it, and it varies a lot person to person.

#27 — Day 16 (content)

OLD: This framing is inaccurate and, for many people, actively counterproductive — nicotine replacement therapy is a well-researched, medically endorsed tool that significantly increases successful quit rates for many people, precisely because it separates the chemical dependency from the ritual and behavioral habit, letting you tackle them in a more manageable sequence rather than fighting both simultaneously at full intensity.

NEW: This framing is wrong and, for many people, actively harmful — the patch and the gum are legitimate tools that doctors and pharmacists recommend every day, precisely because they let you fight the chemical hook and the hand-to-mouth ritual one at a time instead of both at once at full strength.

#29 — Day 22 (content)

OLD: Nicotine's addictive grip re-establishes remarkably fast compared to many other substances — some research suggests dependency pathways can reactivate within days of resuming regular use, even after a significant period of abstinence.

NEW: 'Just one' almost never stays one. Ask anyone who's tried it.

#30 — Day 24 (content)

OLD: Someone who believes 'I am a smoker who's currently not smoking' is, research suggests, more vulnerable to relapse than someone who's shifted to believing 'I am someone who doesn't smoke' — the second framing treats not smoking as who you actually are now, rather than a temporary deviation from your 'true' smoking self.

NEW: A man who says 'I'm a smoker who's not smoking right now' is still holding the door open. The one who says 'I don't smoke' has closed it. Ask anyone with years behind them how they talk about themselves — it's the second way, every time.

#32 — Day 26 (content)

OLD: Behavioral counseling, whether individual or group-based, also has real evidence behind it, particularly when combined with medication or nicotine replacement — the combination tends to outperform either approach alone by a meaningful margin, according to research on cessation outcomes.

NEW: Counseling helps too, one-on-one or in a group — and plenty of people who finally quit for good will tell you it took the counselor plus the patch, not either one alone.

Substances

#40 — Day 12 (content)

OLD: Substance use disorder has a substantial genetic component — research consistently shows that having a parent or close family member with addiction significantly increases your own risk, independent of environment alone.

NEW: This runs in families — if a parent or someone close to you fought addiction, you likely started closer to the edge than other people do. That's not your imagination, and it was never your fault.

#41 — Day 14 (content)

OLD: It's worth stating this clearly and directly: substance use disorder is a real, diagnosable medical condition shaped by genetics, brain chemistry, environment, trauma, and circumstance — most of which were never fully within your control to begin with.

NEW: It's worth stating clearly and directly: substance use disorder is a real medical condition that doctors diagnose and treat — shaped by family history, environment, trauma, and circumstance, most of which were never within your control to begin with.

#42 — Day 15 (content)

OLD: Dopamine system recovery deserves specific mention: many substances, especially stimulants and opioids, significantly alter your brain's natural reward system, and it commonly takes weeks to months for this system to recalibrate toward a more natural baseline.

NEW: The flatness deserves specific mention: after stimulants or opioids especially, joy takes a while to come back online. Food tastes like nothing, music does nothing, nothing feels worth doing. Nearly everyone in recovery describes this stretch — and nearly everyone who holds on watches it lift, over weeks and months, not days.

#44 — Day 16 (content)

OLD: For opioid use disorder specifically, medications like buprenorphine (Suboxone), methadone, and naltrexone have strong, extensive research support for significantly improving long-term recovery outcomes —

including reducing overdose death — compared to abstinence-only approaches alone.

NEW: For opioid use disorder specifically, medications like buprenorphine (Suboxone), methadone, and naltrexone are standard tools doctors prescribe every day — because they keep people alive, out of overdose, and in recovery in a way white-knuckle abstinence often can't.

#45 — Day 16 (content)

OLD: These medications work differently than the substances they're treating dependency on — they stabilize brain chemistry without producing the same intense high, reduce cravings, and for many people, provide the physiological stability that finally makes the rest of recovery work — therapy, rebuilding relationships, building a new life — actually possible to engage with.

NEW: These medications work differently than the substances they're replacing — they steady you without the high, quiet the cravings, and for many people provide the stable ground that finally makes the rest of recovery — therapy, rebuilding relationships, building a life — actually possible.

Gambling

#51 — Day 2 (content)

OLD: Problem gambling is associated with one of the highest rates of suicidal ideation and suicide attempts of any addictive disorder — higher, in several large studies, than alcohol or drug addiction alone.

NEW: Problem gambling carries more suicidal despair than almost any other addiction — the people who answer crisis lines will tell you gambling calls are among the darkest they take.

#52 — Day 2 (content)

OLD: Researchers believe this is connected to the specific nature of gambling losses: they are often sudden, catastrophic, financially quantifiable, and experienced with an acute sense of personal responsibility and shame that can feel inescapable.

NEW: Part of why: the losses are sudden, exact to the dollar, and land with a crushing sense of personal fault that can feel inescapable. It isn't — but on the worst night it feels that way, which is exactly why the number above exists.

#53 — Day 4 (content)

OLD: To recover from gambling addiction, it helps enormously to understand what's actually happening neurologically, because it reframes the struggle from a moral failing into a predictable response to a powerful stimulus.

NEW: To recover from gambling, it helps enormously to see the machinery for what it is, because it turns a moral failing into a rigged game you finally understand.

#54 — Day 4 (content)

OLD: Every form of gambling activates your brain's dopamine system, the same system involved in substance addictions, but gambling has a unique feature: the 'near miss.' A near miss is an outcome that is technically a loss but is structured to feel almost like a win — two matching symbols on a slot machine with the third just barely missing, a lottery number that's one digit off, a bet that would have hit if the game had gone one more minute.

NEW: Gambling delivers the same kind of rush as any substance — with one trick that's all its own: the 'near miss.' A near miss is technically a loss built to feel like almost-a-win — two matching symbols with the third just off, a lottery number one digit away, a bet that dies in the final minute.

#55 — Day 4 (content)

OLD: Neuroimaging studies have shown that near misses activate reward circuitry in the brain almost as strongly as actual wins do, even though they are, financially, complete losses.

NEW: A near miss lights you up almost like a real win — your body celebrates while your wallet takes a complete loss. Any gambler who's chased 'so close' all night knows exactly what that feels like.

#56 — Day 4 (content)

OLD: Modern slot machines and many betting apps are deliberately engineered to maximize the frequency of near misses because game designers know, from decades of behavioral research, that near misses keep people playing longer than a simple string of clean losses would.

NEW: Modern slots and betting apps serve you near misses on purpose and often, because the people who build them know a near miss keeps a player in the chair far longer than a clean string of losses ever would.

#57 — Day 4 (content)

OLD: It stops being a personal contest you keep losing and starts looking like what it actually is — a system with a guaranteed mathematical edge, using well-researched psychological triggers, built by an industry that profits directly from your continued play.

NEW: It stops being a personal contest you keep losing and starts looking like what it actually is — a system with a guaranteed mathematical edge, tuned over decades to keep you playing, built by an industry that profits directly from your continued play.

#58 — Day 12 (content)

OLD: Some people in recovery find it helpful to make their phone's home screen deliberately boring during early recovery — removing app icons for browsers or app stores from the home screen (requiring an extra step to search for them, adding friction), turning off notification previews, or using grayscale display mode, which some research suggests reduces the dopamine pull of app interfaces generally.

NEW: Some people in recovery find it helpful to make their phone's home screen deliberately boring during early recovery — removing app icons for browsers or app stores from the home screen (requiring an extra step to search for them, adding friction), turning off notification previews, or using grayscale display mode, which drains the color that makes apps feel so tappable.

#59 — Day 13 (content)

OLD: This isn't just a metaphor — it's a documented effect of the immersive, rhythmic, reward-anticipation state that extended play induces, sometimes called a 'gambling trance' or 'dark flow' state in research literature.

NEW: This isn't just a metaphor — players themselves call it the 'gambling trance': hours vanish inside that rhythmic, locked-in state, and you surface not remembering choosing to stay.

#60 — Day 16 (content)

OLD: The good news is that your dopamine system responds to a much wider range of experiences than gambling alone, and many of them are available to you right now.

NEW: The good news is that the rush gambling hijacked responds to a much wider range of experiences, and many of them are available to you right now.

#61 — Day 16 (content)

OLD: Physical exercise, particularly anything with a competitive or skill-progression element, produces genuine dopamine and endorphin responses and gives you measurable, visible progress over time — a slower but far more stable reward curve than gambling's, but a real one.

NEW: Physical exercise, especially anything competitive or with visible skill progression, gives you a genuine lift and real, measurable progress — a slower reward than gambling's, but one that's actually yours to keep.

#62 — Day 18 (content)

OLD: If you've associated watching sports with betting for years, simply watching a game, even alone at home with no intention to bet, can trigger a strong urge, because the neural association between 'sports on screen' and 'betting opportunity' has been repeatedly reinforced.

NEW: If sports and betting have been welded together for years, just watching a game — alone, no intention to bet — can set off a strong pull. You wired that link one bet at a time, and it unwires the same way: slowly, with repetition.

#64 — Day 20 (content)

OLD: The research on cue-reactivity in addiction is clear on this point: physical environments associated with past use or gambling can trigger genuine physiological arousal and craving responses, sometimes stronger than purely emotional triggers, because they engage automatic, less consciously mediated learning circuits.

NEW: Anyone in recovery will tell you: places carry the pull. Walk past the old casino, open the old app's login screen, and your body reacts before your mind gets a vote — often harder than any feeling does.

#65 — Day 22 (content)

OLD: This isn't a formality repeated out of caution — the research on this is specific and serious, and the period immediately following a significant gambling loss, particularly one that reactivates old debt or breaks a period of progress, is a genuinely elevated-risk window.

NEW: This isn't a formality — the hours and days right after a heavy loss, especially one that reopens old debt or breaks a run of progress, are the most dangerous stretch in a gambler's life. Treat them that way.

#66 — Day 23 (content)

OLD: Sustained gambling recovery is rarely a solo project, and today is about taking stock of the support infrastructure around you, because the research on addiction recovery broadly, and gambling recovery specifically, consistently shows that people with active, ongoing support systems have meaningfully better long-term outcomes than people relying on willpower and isolated effort alone.

NEW: Sustained gambling recovery is rarely a solo project, and today is about taking stock of the support around you, because the people who make it long-term are almost never the ones going it alone on willpower.

#67 — Day 23 (content)

OLD: Beyond GA, individual therapy with a clinician who has specific experience treating gambling disorder (not just general addiction) can be valuable, particularly cognitive behavioral therapy approaches, which have solid research support specifically for gambling disorder and directly address many of the cognitive distortions covered in this program — loss chasing, the gambler's fallacy, the illusion of control.

NEW: Beyond GA, individual therapy with someone who specifically treats gambling (not just addiction generally) can be valuable — especially the practical, thought-challenging kind that goes straight at loss chasing, the gambler's fallacy, and the illusion of control covered in this program.

#68 — Day 24 (content)

OLD: Multiple studies and countless individual accounts within the gambling treatment field describe exactly this pattern: a significant win occurring during active addiction rarely ends the addiction, and often intensifies it, because it appears to validate the very belief system (I can win it back, I have an edge, this time is different) that recovery requires dismantling.

NEW: Ask around any GA room and you'll hear the same story: the big win never ended anyone's gambling. It funded the next stretch of it — because it seemed to prove the exact beliefs (I can win it back, I have an edge, this time is different) that recovery requires tearing down.

#69 — Day 27 (content)

OLD: This is analogous to why most substance addiction treatment approaches don't recommend 'just one drink' for someone recovering from alcohol addiction, even though a single drink is objectively harmless for most people — the risk isn't really about that one drink's direct effects, it's about what reactivating the behavioral and neurological pattern tends to trigger afterward.

NEW: It's the same reason recovery programs don't recommend 'just one drink' to a man who fought alcohol — the danger was never that one drink, it's what reopening the old pattern reliably sets off.

Social media

#70 — Day 1 (content)

OLD: Both things are true at once: social media genuinely can connect you to people you love and information you need, and the specific way these platforms are built is the product of some of the most sophisticated behavioral engineering in existence, developed by teams that explicitly study attention, habit formation, and reward psychology to maximize a single metric — time spent on the app.

NEW: Both things are true at once: social media genuinely can connect you to people you love — and these platforms are built by teams paid extremely well to do one thing: keep you on the app longer.

#71 — Day 2 (content)

OLD: The autoplay of the next video, the infinite scroll with no natural stopping point, the red notification badges specifically chosen because red is documented to draw the eye and create urgency more than other colors, the 'stories' format designed to expire and create time pressure to check now rather than later — none of these are accidents or simply 'how technology naturally works.' They are the product of extensive research and testing, conducted by teams whose success is measured directly by increases in time-on-platform and daily active use, sometimes called 'engagement' in industry language, which is really a more neutral-sounding term for what is, from a behavioral psychology standpoint, compulsion engineering.

NEW: The autoplay of the next video, the infinite scroll with no natural stopping point, the red badges (red, because it's the color your eye can't ignore), the stories that expire so you check now rather than later — none of it is an accident. Every piece was tested on millions of people and kept because it worked. The industry calls it 'engagement.' A plainer word for what's being engineered is compulsion.

#72 — Day 3 (content)

OLD: Today, let's go deeper into the specific psychological mechanism that makes these platforms so compelling moment to moment: the variable reward schedule, the same core mechanism discussed in gambling research and used deliberately in slot machine design.

NEW: Today, let's go deeper into the mechanism that makes these platforms so hard to put down moment to moment: the slot-machine trick — you never know which pull pays out, so you keep pulling.

#73 — Day 3 (content)

OLD: Your brain's dopamine system responds most powerfully not to the reward itself but to the uncertainty and anticipation preceding it — this is well-established in neuroscience research going back decades, and it's precisely why the 'pull to refresh' gesture, requiring an active physical motion before content loads, was deliberately modeled on the physical pull-lever action of a slot machine by the engineers who designed it, a fact one of them has publicly acknowledged in interviews.

NEW: The pull lives in the maybe, not the payoff — you feel it every time you drag down to refresh. That gesture wasn't an accident either: one of its own designers has said publicly it was modeled on the pull of a slot machine lever.

#74 — Day 4 (content)

OLD: Decades of social comparison research in psychology, dating well before social media existed, established that upward social comparison — comparing yourself to people who appear to be doing better than you — reliably decreases self-esteem and mood, especially when the comparison feels close to home rather than distant and abstract.

NEW: Comparing up — measuring yourself against people who look like they're winning — has made humans feel smaller since long before phones existed. The feed just made it endless and put it in your pocket.

#75 — Day 4 (content)

OLD: Multiple large studies have found correlations between heavy social media use, particularly image-focused platforms, and increased rates of depression, anxiety, and low self-esteem, with the relationship appearing strongest in passive use — scrolling and viewing without actively posting or engaging — compared to active use focused on genuine communication with specific people you know.

NEW: Heavy scrolling and feeling worse travel together, and the worst version is the silent kind — watching other people's lives for hours without saying a word to anyone. Most people can confirm that one in their own chest without any help.

#76 — Day 8 (content)

OLD: Research on media consumption during crisis periods has consistently found that heavy, repeated exposure to distressing news content correlates with increased anxiety, sleep disruption, and even symptoms resembling secondary traumatic stress, without a corresponding increase in genuinely useful information beyond a certain point — most breaking news events don't meaningfully change minute to minute, which means repeated checking mostly just re-exposes you to the same distressing content and reactions rather than providing new, actionable information.

NEW: Doomscrolling doesn't inform you, it marinates you. Breaking news barely changes minute to minute — checking again mostly re-runs the same distressing loop through your head, and you feel it that night when you can't sleep.

#77 — Day 9 (content)

OLD: The single most effective structural intervention here, supported by both research and widespread clinical recommendation, is keeping your phone physically outside the bedroom, using a separate alarm clock if needed.

NEW: The single most effective move here — boring as it sounds, and everyone who's tried it says the same — is the phone sleeping outside the bedroom, with a cheap alarm clock doing the one job you actually needed it for.

#78 — Day 10 (content)

OLD: Grayscale display mode, which removes color from your phone's entire interface, is a less commonly known but research-supported intervention; some studies suggest it meaningfully reduces the visual reward salience of app interfaces specifically designed with vibrant colors and red notification badges to capture attention, making the whole experience of using your phone somewhat less viscerally compelling.

NEW: Grayscale mode — draining the color from your whole phone — is the sleeper move: a gray feed is a boring feed. Apps are painted in candy colors and red badges for a reason. Try three days of gray and feel the difference.

#79 — Day 11 (content)

OLD: Multiple studies have found that the mere presence of a phone on a table during a conversation, even face-down and silent, measurably reduces the perceived quality of connection and empathy in that conversation compared to conversations without a phone present, simply because part of both people's attention remains allocated to the possibility of the phone activating.

NEW: A phone on the table changes the table — even face-down and silent. Part of everyone's attention stays on it, waiting for it to light up. You've felt this from the other side of the table; assume they feel it from yours.

#80 — Day 12 (content)

OLD: A post that performs well produces a real dopamine response and a temporary lift in mood and confidence.

NEW: A post that performs well gives you a genuine hit — a temporary lift in mood and confidence.

#81 — Day 15 (content)

OLD: Constantly filling every gap with external stimulation, as compulsive phone checking does, may meaningfully reduce access to this kind of reflective, creative mental processing, which some researchers believe contributes to the sense many heavy social media users report of feeling mentally scattered or having a harder time sitting with their own thoughts.

NEW: Filling every gap with the feed leaves no room for the wandering your mind does its best work in — notice how few of your good ideas have ever arrived mid-scroll, and how scattered a heavy scrolling day leaves you.

#82 — Day 16 (content)

OLD: The good news is that dopamine and reward circuitry respond to a genuinely wide range of experiences, many of which offer more durable and less costly satisfaction than social media's engineered, variable-reward stimulation.

NEW: The good news is that the lift you were scrolling for is available from a genuinely wide range of things — most of them more filling, and none of them engineered against you.

#83 — Day 16 (content)

OLD: Physical activity, particularly anything involving novelty or social connection (a new sport, a class, a hiking group), activates reward circuitry through multiple pathways at once — the physical endorphin response, the sense of accomplishment, and often genuine in-person social connection, which offers a different and often more satisfying kind of social reward than social media's mediated version.

NEW: Physical activity, especially with novelty or other people in it (a new sport, a class, a hiking group), pays you back three ways at once — the physical lift, the sense of progress, and face-to-face connection, which lands in a way the feed's version never quite does.

#84 — Day 16 (content)

OLD: Reading, particularly fiction, offers a different kind of engagement — a genuinely absorbing, extended narrative experience that some research suggests activates similar 'flow state' mechanisms as compelling media, but on a slower timescale that's less compatible with the fragmented, constantly-interrupted attention pattern social media tends to train.

NEW: Reading, particularly fiction, can swallow you whole the way a feed only pretends to — a slower, deeper absorption that the fractured attention social media trains finds difficult at first, and then remembers how to do.

#85 — Day 17 (content)

OLD: Some platforms, particularly those centered heavily on photos and short-form video, carry a specific and well-researched additional risk worth addressing directly: their effect on body image, particularly though not exclusively for younger users and women.

NEW: Some platforms, especially the photo and short-video ones, carry one more risk worth naming directly: what they do to how you see your own body — hardest on younger users and women, but not only them.

#86 — Day 17 (content)

OLD: Multiple large-scale studies, including internal research from major platforms themselves that was later made public through investigative reporting and whistleblower disclosures, have found associations between heavy use of image-focused platforms and increased body dissatisfaction, disordered eating attitudes, and, in some studies, increased rates of self-harm ideation among teenage users, particularly teenage girls.

NEW: The platforms' own people knew. Internal findings that only became public through leaks and investigative reporting showed heavy use of image-focused apps going hand in hand with worse body image, worse eating attitudes, and worse — especially for teenage girls.

#87 — Day 17 (content)

OLD: This isn't a fringe finding — it's been substantial enough to prompt Congressional hearings, regulatory scrutiny, and, in at least one documented internal case, research conducted by a platform's own team that found the platform made body image issues worse for a significant proportion of teen users who were already struggling, research the company reportedly didn't make fully public until investigative journalists obtained it.

NEW: This isn't a fringe claim — it was serious enough to put executives in front of Congress, and in the most famous case a platform's own team found it was making body image worse for a large share of teens who were already struggling, and the company sat on that until journalists forced it out.

#88 — Day 17 (content)

OLD: Concrete steps worth considering: actively curating your feed to include a wider range of body types and unedited, unfiltered content, which some research suggests can meaningfully improve body satisfaction over time; being deliberately aware of and skeptical toward content you know or suspect is heavily filtered or edited; and, if body image distress feels significant or is affecting your eating patterns, relationship with food, or overall mental health, considering support from a therapist who specializes in body image or disordered eating, since this specific dimension of social media's harm sometimes requires more targeted support than general digital wellness strategies alone can provide.

NEW: Concrete steps worth considering: curate your feed toward real, unedited bodies — people who do this say what 'normal' looks like recalibrates within weeks; stay consciously skeptical of anything you suspect is filtered or edited; and if body image distress feels significant or is touching your eating or your mental health, take it to a therapist who works with body image or disordered eating — that specific harm deserves more than general screen-time advice.

#89 — Day 18 (content)

OLD: Online disagreements often escalate faster and more harshly than in-person ones, partly due to what researchers call the 'online disinhibition effect' — the well-documented tendency for people to say things online, shielded by physical distance, partial anonymity, and the absence of real-time nonverbal feedback (a hurt facial expression, a pained tone of voice) that would normally moderate cruelty in face-to-face interaction, that they would rarely say to someone's face.

NEW: Online arguments escalate faster and hit harder than in-person ones for a simple reason everyone has felt: people say things to a screen they would never say to a face. No flinch, no hurt look, no voice cracking — all the brakes are missing.

#90 — Day 18 (content)

OLD: Beyond direct targeting, simply witnessing conflict-heavy content — arguments in comment sections, coordinated online outrage campaigns, political or ideological hostility between strangers — carries its own toll, even when you're not personally involved, contributing to what some researchers describe as a kind of secondary stress response from repeated exposure to hostility and conflict, similar in a milder form to the doomscrolling pattern discussed on Day 8.

NEW: And you don't have to be in the fight to pay for it — just soaking in comment-section wars and stranger-on-stranger outrage leaves a residue, the same way doomscrolling does. You close the app carrying a fight that was never yours.

#91 — Day 19 (content)

OLD: One of the more paradoxical harms of social media, given that these platforms are explicitly marketed around connection, is a documented association in some research between heavy use and increased feelings of loneliness and social isolation, particularly when use is predominantly passive (scrolling and viewing rather than active messaging with specific people you know well).

NEW: Here's the paradox nobody selling 'connection' mentions: the heaviest scrollers are so often the loneliest people in the room — especially the ones who watch everything and say nothing.

#92 — Day 19 (content)

OLD: Part of what seems to explain this paradox is that social media often provides what researchers sometimes call 'social snacking' — brief, low-effort engagement that produces a small hit of social feeling without the deeper investment and vulnerability that genuine connection requires, and that over time, if it substitutes for rather than supplements real relationship investment, can leave people feeling more isolated despite spending hours daily on platforms explicitly built around social connection.

NEW: Part of the answer is that the feed serves social snacks — tiny, effortless tastes of contact that feel like connection while asking nothing of you. Snack all day, every day, and you can go months without a real meal — hours daily on 'social' platforms, and lonelier all the time.

#93 — Day 20 (content)

OLD: Just as with any compulsive behavior, certain specific times and physical contexts carry disproportionate risk for social media use, and identifying yours specifically allows for more targeted structural intervention than a general intention to 'use less.' Common high-risk windows worth examining honestly in your own life: the first fifteen minutes after waking up, when your phone is often the first thing reached for before your mind has even fully oriented to the day, which research suggests can set an anxious, reactive, externally-focused tone for the hours that follow; the last thirty to sixty minutes before sleep, covered specifically on Day 9; transition moments throughout the day, like waiting for a meeting to start, walking between locations, or the few minutes after finishing one task and before starting another; and the bathroom, which for many people has become an almost automatic phone-use location, sometimes extending bathroom visits considerably beyond their functional purpose.

NEW: Just as with any compulsive behavior, certain times and places carry outsized risk, and naming yours allows sharper defenses than a vague plan to 'use less.' The usual suspects: the first fifteen minutes after waking, when the phone gets to set the day's tone before your own mind does; the last half hour before sleep, covered on Day 9; the in-between moments — waiting for a meeting to start, walking between places, the gap between finishing one thing and starting the next; and the bathroom, which for a lot of people has quietly become a phone appointment that runs long.

#94 — Day 26 (content)

OLD: Some structural changes are worth treating as permanent, non-negotiable defaults regardless of how much progress you feel you've made: keeping your phone out of the bedroom overnight, given the well-established sleep research discussed on Day 9; maintaining reduced or eliminated non-essential notifications, since notification-driven checking tends to creep back quickly if notifications are re-enabled even after a long period of reduced use; and phone-free time during meals and direct conversations with people who matter to you, given the relationship research discussed on Day 11.

NEW: Some structural changes are worth treating as permanent, non-negotiable defaults no matter how much progress you feel you've made: the phone out of the bedroom overnight — you've felt what it does to your sleep; notifications kept off, since notification-driven checking creeps back fast the moment they're re-enabled; and phone-free meals and conversations with the people who matter — Day 11 covered what a phone on the table does to the table.

Gaming

#96 — Day 1 (content)

OLD: Gaming addiction is now formally recognized as a clinical condition — 'Gaming Disorder' was added to the World Health Organization's International Classification of Diseases in 2019, defined by impaired control over gaming, increasing priority given to gaming over other life interests and daily activities, and continuation of gaming despite negative consequences, persisting for at least twelve months in a way that causes significant impairment.

NEW: Gaming addiction is real enough that the World Health Organization put 'Gaming Disorder' on its official books in 2019 — defined by exactly what you'd recognize: control slipping, gaming climbing over everything else that matters, and continuing anyway while the consequences stack up, for a year or more.

#98 — Day 2 (content)

OLD: Variable reward schedules, the same mechanism discussed in gambling and slot machine psychology, are deliberately built into many games through randomized loot drops, critical hit chances, and randomized enemy encounters, all of which produce a variable-ratio dopamine response more compelling than predictable rewards would be.

NEW: The slot-machine trick is built straight in: randomized loot drops, critical hits, random encounters — you never know which pull pays out, so you keep pulling, far longer than any predictable reward could hold you.

#99 — Day 2 (content)

OLD: Many modern games, especially live-service titles, also use daily login rewards and daily quests specifically engineered to build habitual, near-automatic daily engagement — missing a day often means losing a reward streak or falling behind other players, which activates loss aversion (the psychological principle, covered in gambling research, that losses feel roughly twice as painful as equivalent gains feel good) to pull you back in even on days you might not otherwise have chosen to play.

NEW: Many modern games, especially live-service ones, run daily login rewards and daily quests engineered to make playing automatic — miss a day and you lose a streak or fall behind, and losing something stings about twice as hard as winning it felt good. The designers know that math. That's why the streak exists.

#100 — Day 2 (content)

OLD: But a significant portion of the modern gaming industry, particularly the free-to-play mobile and live-service sectors, has explicitly adopted engagement-maximization practices from the same research base used in gambling and social media design, sometimes hiring the same consultants and researchers.

NEW: But a big slice of the modern industry, especially free-to-play mobile and live-service, runs the casino's playbook on purpose — sometimes hiring the same consultants who wrote it.

#101 — Day 3 (content)

OLD: Many people significantly underestimate their own spending on these mechanics because purchases happen in small increments, often through stored payment methods that remove the friction of re-entering card details each time, and because in-game currencies (gems, coins, crystals) are deliberately used instead of direct real-money pricing specifically because research shows this abstraction reduces the psychological weight of spending compared to seeing an actual dollar amount, a well-documented industry practice sometimes described as reducing 'the pain of paying.' Beyond loot boxes specifically, 'pay-to-win' and 'pay-to-progress' mechanics in many games create a related pressure: falling behind other players unless you spend money, which can drive compulsive purchasing even without the randomized element, through a more straightforward but still psychologically powerful competitive pressure.

NEW: Many people badly underestimate their spending on these mechanics: purchases come in small bites through saved cards, and the gems-and-coins layer exists precisely because handing over 'gems' doesn't sting the way watching real dollars leave does — the industry's own term for what they're removing is 'the pain of paying.' Beyond loot boxes, 'pay-to-win' and 'pay-to-progress' mechanics add a plainer pressure: fall behind unless you spend — which can drive compulsive purchasing with no randomness needed at all.

#102 — Day 4 (content)

OLD: Game designers understand sunk cost extremely well, and progression systems are frequently built specifically to maximize this effect — long unlock chains, seasonal content that resets or expires (creating urgency to finish before losing progress), and prestige or rebirth systems that ask you to give up accumulated progress in exchange for a new, longer progression track, precisely because players who have invested heavily are measurably less likely to quit than players just starting out, a pattern game designers explicitly study and optimize for under names like 'time-to-value' and 'retention curves.' It's worth being honest today about how much of your own continued play is driven by genuine, present-moment enjoyment versus a sense of obligation to past investment — hours already spent, purchases already made, a rank already partially earned.

NEW: Game designers understand sunk cost better than almost anyone — long unlock chains, seasonal content that expires so you rush to finish, prestige systems that trade your accumulated progress for a longer ladder — all built on a simple observed truth: a player who has invested heavily almost never walks away, and the industry tracks exactly that under tidy names like 'retention.' It's worth being honest today about how much of your own play is present-moment enjoyment versus obligation to hours and money already sunk.

#103 — Day 9 (content)

OLD: Prolonged sedentary time is the most obvious concern — sitting for many consecutive hours, common in extended gaming sessions, is independently associated with increased risk of cardiovascular problems, weight gain, and musculoskeletal issues, largely independent of whether you also get exercise at other times, since the research on sedentary behavior suggests that extended unbroken sitting carries risk somewhat separately from total weekly activity levels.

NEW: Marathon sitting is the most obvious cost — your body was not built for six unbroken hours in a chair, and it keeps the receipts: the stiffness, the weight, the heart working harder — largely regardless of whether you also exercise at other times. Breaking up the sitting matters on its own.

#106 — Day 18 (content)

OLD: For parents specifically, gaming can affect the quality of attention and presence available to children, sometimes in ways children notice and internalize more than parents realize — children of heavily gaming parents have described, in various research and clinical accounts, feeling less prioritized or less able to get a parent's full attention compared to a screen, which is worth taking seriously if it applies to your situation, given how much these early relational patterns can shape a child's own sense of worth and their eventual relationship with screens and gaming themselves.

NEW: For parents specifically, gaming can quietly take the attention your kids can feel going missing — kids of heavy-gaming parents describe knowing they ranked below the screen, and carrying that. If it lands close to home, take it seriously: those early patterns shape a child's sense of worth, and their own eventual screens.

#111 — Day 27 (content)

OLD: The difficulty is that, as covered throughout this program, compulsive gaming isn't primarily about any single session's length — it's about a conditioned relationship between specific cues (the game's interface, its sounds, its reward systems) and a well-established behavioral pattern, and reintroducing even a brief, well-intentioned session can reactivate that full conditioned pattern considerably faster and more completely than the 'just one match' framing would predict, precisely because the underlying neural and behavioral pathways built over months or years of heavy play don't fully disappear during a period of reduced or abstinent gaming — they remain available to be reactivated by renewed exposure to the specific cues that originally built them.

NEW: The difficulty is that compulsive gaming was never about one session's length — it's a trained link between the cues (that interface, those sounds, that reward loop) and the old pattern, and one well-intentioned session can wake the whole thing far faster than 'just one match' predicts. The groove you wore over years doesn't vanish while you're away — it waits for the cue.

Food / Binging

#116 — Day 3 (content)

OLD: Some researchers describe this engineered hyperpalatability as functioning similarly to addictive substances at a neurological level — activating dopamine reward pathways strongly and reliably, in ways that can create genuine craving and loss-of-control eating patterns that have relatively little to do with willpower or self-discipline and much more to do with the specific chemical and sensory engineering of the product itself.

NEW: Some of this stuff is built to hit the way a substance hits — ask anyone who has tried to eat exactly one chip. Real craving, real loss of control, and very little of it about your discipline: the product was designed to win.

#117 — Day 4 (content)

OLD: It's also immediately accessible in a way many other coping strategies aren't, doesn't require anyone else's involvement or availability, and produces a real, physiologically genuine effect — eating, particularly foods high in sugar and fat, does activate reward and comfort-related neurochemistry, which is part of why it can feel so effective as a short-term coping tool even when it doesn't address whatever emotional difficulty prompted it.

NEW: It's also always available, needs nobody else's involvement, and genuinely works for a minute — sugar and fat really do comfort, which is exactly why eating feels so effective in the moment even when it solves nothing underneath.

#118 — Day 5 (content)

OLD: This can be genuinely difficult to accept, particularly in a culture that consistently frames restriction and willpower as the answer to eating struggles, but the research on this is substantial: a significant proportion of people who develop binge eating patterns report that their binge eating developed after or alongside a history of dieting, not before it.

NEW: This can be genuinely hard to accept in a culture that keeps prescribing more restriction and more willpower, but ask around any group of people who binge: for a striking number of them, the bingeing showed up after the dieting started, not before it.

#120 — Day 7 (content)

OLD: It's also worth naming something important as you move into the coming weeks: this program's approach, grounded in the research on restrict-binge cycles, will not ask you to restrict, diet, or eliminate specific foods as a path to recovery.

NEW: It's also worth naming something important as you move into the coming weeks: this program will not ask you to restrict, diet, or ban foods as a path to recovery — the restrict-binge seesaw is the engine of this thing, not the fix.

#121 — Day 8 (content)

OLD: If restriction and dieting are, for many people, a primary driver of the restrict-binge cycle rather than its solution, then a 'just use more willpower to restrict further' approach isn't a neutral, ineffective strategy — it's one that tends to intensify the very cycle it claims to address, setting up a pattern where each new diet attempt, driven by renewed willpower and often genuine hope, eventually breaks down into a loss-of-control episode, which then gets interpreted, painfully and inaccurately, as further proof of personal weakness or lack of discipline, rather than as the predictable physiological and psychological consequence of restriction that the research actually shows it to be.

NEW: If restriction and dieting are, for many people, the engine of the restrict-binge cycle rather than its solution, then 'just restrict harder' isn't neutral advice that merely fails — it winds the spring tighter. Each new diet, powered by fresh willpower and real hope, eventually snaps into a loss-of-control episode, which then gets read — painfully and wrongly — as more proof of personal weakness, when it was the predictable end of the restriction itself. Check it against your own history; most people who've lived a few laps of the cycle recognize it immediately.

#122 — Day 9 (content)

OLD: This isn't about excusing or ignoring the pattern; it's about recognizing that self-compassion, not self-punishment, is what the actual research on behavior change shows supports lasting recovery.

NEW: This isn't about excusing the pattern — it's that self-punishment keeps the cycle running, and self-compassion is what the people who actually get free of it keep pointing back to.

#123 — Day 11 (content)

OLD: Mindful eating is a specific, well-researched practice worth building deliberately into your recovery, because compulsive eating patterns, along with dieting and restriction, tend to disconnect people from their body's natural hunger and fullness signals over time — years of either ignoring hunger through restriction or eating past fullness during compulsive episodes can genuinely reduce your ability to accurately sense and trust these signals, which is a skill, not a fixed trait, and one that can be deliberately rebuilt with practice.

NEW: Mindful eating is a practice worth building deliberately into your recovery, because compulsive eating, dieting, and restriction all teach you to stop hearing your own hunger and fullness — years of overriding those signals in both directions genuinely dulls them. Tuning back in is a skill, not a fixed trait, and it rebuilds with practice.

#124 — Day 11 (content)

OLD: Mindful eating, at its core, involves bringing genuine attention to the experience of eating — noticing the taste, texture, and satisfaction of food, checking in periodically with your body's hunger and fullness cues, and eating without significant distraction, at least for some portion of your meals, since eating while distracted (in front of a screen, while working, while scrolling a phone) has been shown in research to reduce awareness of how much you've eaten and reduce the satisfaction derived from the meal, which can contribute to eating more than intended or feeling less satisfied despite eating enough.

NEW: Mindful eating, at its core, is paying attention while you eat — the taste, the texture, whether you're still hungry — and eating without a screen for at least some meals. You already know what distracted eating does: the food vanishes, you barely tasted it, and you're somehow both finished and unsatisfied.

#125 — Day 17 (content)

OLD: Sleep itself plays a role too: research on sleep and appetite regulation shows that inadequate or poor-quality sleep measurably increases hunger hormones and cravings for high-calorie, palatable foods the following day, creating a compounding cycle where late-night eating disrupts sleep, which increases the following day's food cravings and reduces the following evening's capacity to manage them, a cycle worth naming directly if it resonates with your own experience.

NEW: Sleep plays a role too, and you've lived it: after a short night, the next day is hungrier, the pull toward heavy comfort food is stronger, and the evening's resistance is thinner. Late-night eating wrecks the sleep, the short sleep feeds the next night's eating — around and around.

Shopping / Spending

#130 — Day 2 (title)

OLD: The Psychology of the Purchase: Dopamine and the Hunt

NEW: The Psychology of the Purchase: The Hunt

#131 — Day 2 (content)

OLD: Understanding what's actually happening neurologically during a shopping episode can be genuinely relieving, because it reframes the struggle away from a simple lack of discipline and toward an accurate picture of what you've actually been navigating.

NEW: Understanding what's actually happening during a shopping episode can be genuinely relieving, because it reframes the struggle away from a simple lack of discipline and toward an accurate picture of what you've been up against.

#132 — Day 2 (content)

OLD: Research on compulsive buying has consistently found that much of the reward from shopping occurs before the actual purchase — during the anticipation, the searching, the browsing, what's sometimes informally called 'the hunt.' Dopamine, the neurotransmitter centrally involved in reward and motivation, is released significantly during this anticipatory phase, often more than during the moment of purchase itself or afterward, which helps explain a pattern many people with compulsive shopping describe: the browsing and searching itself can feel almost as compelling as the eventual purchase, sometimes more so, and the item, once acquired, frequently produces less satisfaction than anticipated, sometimes described as feeling flat, disappointing, or oddly anticlimactic almost immediately after buying it.

NEW: Here's the truth every compulsive shopper eventually recognizes: the good part happens before the buying. The searching, the comparing, the cart — the hunt. The rush peaks in the anticipation, and the item itself lands flat — that strange little disappointment, sometimes minutes after checkout, when the thing you had to have is suddenly just a thing in a box.

#133 — Day 3 (content)

OLD: Common emotional drivers worth examining honestly: stress relief, where shopping offers an immediate, accessible distraction and a temporary sense of control or agency during moments that otherwise feel overwhelming or out of your hands; comfort and self-soothing during sadness or low mood, where the anticipation and acquisition of something new provides a genuine, if temporary, mood boost through the dopamine mechanisms discussed yesterday; boredom, where shopping — particularly online browsing — fills unstructured time with stimulation and novelty; a sense of control, particularly for people whose lives feel chaotic or out of their control in other significant ways, where the decisive act of choosing and purchasing something offers a concentrated, achievable sense of agency; and, for some people, a search for identity or self-expression, where purchases represent an attempt to construct or project a particular version of yourself, whether that's a more successful, more put-together, more interesting, or more aspirational identity than the one currently felt day to day.

NEW: Common emotional drivers worth examining honestly: stress relief, where shopping offers an immediate, accessible distraction and a temporary sense of control during moments that otherwise feel out of your hands; comfort and self-soothing during sadness or low mood, where the anticipation and acquisition of something new provides a genuine, if temporary, lift through the hunt-rush covered yesterday; boredom, where shopping — particularly online browsing — fills unstructured time with stimulation and novelty; a sense of control, particularly for people whose lives feel chaotic in other significant ways, where the decisive act of choosing and purchasing offers a concentrated, achievable sense of agency; and, for some people, a search for identity or self-expression, where purchases represent an attempt to construct or project a particular version of yourself — more successful, more put-together, more interesting — than the one currently felt day to day.

#134 — Day 4 (content)

OLD: None of this means you're uniquely susceptible or weak-willed — you're responding to a shopping environment specifically engineered, by well-resourced teams using extensive behavioral research, to overcome exactly the kind of careful, deliberate reconsideration that would otherwise prevent an impulsive purchase.

NEW: None of this means you're uniquely weak-willed — you're up against a shopping environment where every button, banner, and countdown timer was tested on millions of people and kept only if it beat your better judgment.

#135 — Day 5 (content)

OLD: This framing is worth examining critically: splitting a purchase into four smaller payments doesn't change the total amount owed, but it does measurably reduce the psychological weight of the decision in the moment of

purchase, a well-documented effect similar to the in-game currency abstraction discussed in gaming addiction research, where an in-game currency reduces the perceived 'pain' of spending compared to seeing an actual dollar amount.

NEW: This framing deserves a hard look: splitting a purchase into four payments doesn't change what you owe — it changes what you feel at the moment of buying. Same trick as game 'gems': shrink the sting now, keep the debt.

#136 — Day 7 (content)

OLD: Over these six days you've begun looking honestly at your own shopping pattern, learned about the dopamine-driven psychology of anticipation and 'the hunt' that often matters more than the purchase itself, explored the emotional functions shopping has been serving for you, examined the specific ways online shopping platforms are engineered to reduce friction and encourage impulsive purchasing, confronted directly the real financial risk of buy-now-pay-later services and credit card debt, and started mapping your own specific trigger pattern in detail.

NEW: Over these six days you've begun looking honestly at your own shopping pattern, learned about the psychology of the hunt — the anticipation that often matters more than the purchase itself — explored the emotional functions shopping has been serving for you, examined the specific ways online shopping platforms are engineered to reduce friction and encourage impulsive purchasing, confronted directly the real financial risk of buy-now-pay-later services and credit card debt, and started mapping your own specific trigger pattern in detail.

#137 — Day 9 (content)

OLD: A useful practice worth building today is a deliberate pause between the impulse to purchase and the completed purchase itself — even a modest delay, such as waiting twenty-four hours before completing a non-essential purchase, gives the initial dopamine-driven urgency time to fade and allows a more considered, values-aligned decision to emerge, since the intensity of an impulsive urge to buy tends to decrease substantially with even a short delay, in a pattern well-documented across impulse-control research more broadly.

NEW: A useful practice worth building today is a deliberate pause between impulse and purchase — even twenty-four hours. The urgency burns off with time: what felt like need at 9pm is usually a shrug by morning. Try it once and check.

#139 — Day 15 (content)

OLD: For many people with a compulsive shopping pattern, purchases serve a function beyond simple emotional coping or the dopamine-driven hunt discussed earlier this week — they function as a way of constructing or signaling a particular identity, worth examining directly because it's often one of the deeper, less immediately visible drivers of the pattern.

NEW: For many people with a compulsive shopping pattern, purchases serve a function beyond mood repair or the thrill of the hunt discussed earlier this week — they function as a way of constructing or signaling a particular identity, worth examining directly because it's often one of the deeper, less visible drivers of the pattern.

#140 — Day 16 (content)

OLD: The good news, consistent with other categories throughout this broader program, is that dopamine and reward circuitry respond to a wide range of experiences, many of which offer more durable satisfaction than the fleeting reward of a purchase followed by hedonic adaptation, discussed on Day 2.

NEW: The good news, consistent with the rest of this program, is that the itch the hunt was scratching can be scratched a lot of other ways — most of them cheaper, and longer-lasting than a purchase that's already boring by Thursday.

#143 — Day 18 (content)

OLD: This reframe is powerful and well-documented in behavioral economics research — people are measurably more likely to purchase an item they don't need at a steep discount than the same item at full price they do

genuinely need, because the discount itself becomes the primary driver of the purchase decision rather than the item's actual usefulness to you.

NEW: This reframe has teeth, and you can test it against your own receipts: a steep discount sells the discount, not the item. You've bought things you didn't need because the price felt like winning — that's the whole trick.

#145 — Day 21 (content)

OLD: You've built a thorough understanding of the psychological mechanisms — dopamine-driven anticipation, hedonic adaptation, the engineered friction-reduction of online shopping platforms, scarcity and discount marketing — that reframes this struggle away from personal weakness and toward an accurate picture of what you've actually been navigating.

NEW: You've built a thorough understanding of the machinery — the hunt, the wear-off, the one-click frictionlessness, the scarcity and discount pressure — that reframes this struggle away from personal weakness and toward an accurate picture of what you've actually been navigating.

#146 — Day 29 (content)

OLD: New sales events, new marketing tactics, and new platforms will continue to emerge, and it's worth carrying forward the analytical tools this program has built — recognizing the dopamine-driven hunt, recognizing engineered friction reduction and scarcity marketing, recognizing the 'I deserve this' and 'just window shopping' justifications — as transferable skills applicable to whatever new shopping platform or marketing tactic comes next, rather than needing to relearn these dynamics from scratch each time.

NEW: New sales events, new marketing tactics, and new platforms will continue to emerge, and it's worth carrying forward the tools this program has built — recognizing the hunt, the engineered ease, the scarcity clock, the 'I deserve this' and 'just window shopping' stories — as transferable skills for whatever comes next, rather than relearning these dynamics from scratch each time.

#147 — Day 30 (content)

OLD: Changing your relationship with shopping and spending, particularly in a retail environment deliberately engineered with sophisticated behavioral research to encourage impulsive purchasing, is a genuinely difficult undertaking, and the fact that you've engaged seriously with this work, day after day, for thirty days, reflects real and meaningful effort.

NEW: Changing your relationship with spending, inside a retail world built to make buying effortless and stopping hard, is a genuinely difficult undertaking — and you've engaged seriously with it, day after day, for thirty days. That reflects real and meaningful effort.

#148 — Day 30 (content)

OLD: You've built a thorough, accurate understanding of the specific mechanisms — the dopamine-driven hunt, hedonic adaptation, engineered friction reduction, scarcity and discount marketing — that reframes this struggle away from personal weakness and toward an accurate picture of what you've actually been navigating: sophisticated engagement and persuasion engineering built by teams whose business incentives have never been aligned with your financial or emotional wellbeing.

NEW: You've built an accurate map of the machinery — the hunt, the wear-off, the one-click ease, the discount pressure — and an accurate picture of the other side of the table: skilled persuasion built by teams whose incentives were never aligned with your wallet or your peace.

Work

#149 — Day 1 (content)

OLD: Research on work addiction defines it broadly by a persistent, difficult-to-control drive to work, continuing despite negative consequences to health, relationships, or overall wellbeing, often accompanied by anxiety or guilt

when not working, and a pattern where work has become the primary or only reliable source of identity, self-worth, and emotional regulation.

NEW: Work addiction, plainly defined: a drive to work you can't put down, that keeps going as it costs you health, relationships, or peace — usually with anxiety or guilt the moment you stop, and work standing as the only reliable source of identity and worth you've got left.

#150 — Day 3 (content)

OLD: Chronic work-related stress activates sustained elevation of cortisol and other stress hormones, and prolonged elevation of these hormones is associated with a range of health effects including increased blood pressure, disrupted sleep architecture, impaired immune function, and increased risk of cardiovascular disease over time — the World Health Organization and International Labour Organization have specifically identified working long hours (defined in their research as 55 or more hours per week) as associated with significantly increased risk of stroke and heart disease compared to standard working hours, a large-scale global health finding worth taking seriously rather than dismissing as an exaggeration.

NEW: A body that never gets the all-clear pays for it — the blood pressure, the broken sleep, the catching-everything immune system, the heart. And the toll of crushing hours is real enough that the World Health Organization has formally flagged 55-plus-hour weeks as a genuine killer — stroke and heart disease, not burnout-blog talk. Take it seriously rather than wearing it as a badge.

#151 — Day 3 (content)

OLD: Beyond cardiovascular risk, chronic overwork significantly disrupts sleep — both directly, through late hours and pre-sleep work-related stimulation and stress, and indirectly, through cortisol elevation, which interferes with normal sleep architecture even when time is technically available for rest.

NEW: Beyond the heart, chronic overwork wrecks sleep from both ends — the late hours themselves, and the wired, work-buzzing head you take to bed, which keeps real rest out of reach even when time is technically available.

#152 — Day 8 (content)

OLD: Research on recovery from work-related stress has found that genuine psychological detachment from work during non-work hours — not simply being physically away from the workplace, but actually mentally disengaging — is significantly associated with better stress recovery, improved sleep, and reduced burnout risk, which means simply being physically present at home while mentally still tethered to work through constant checking doesn't provide the actual recovery benefit that time away from work is meant to offer.

NEW: Being home isn't the same as being off. If your head is still in the inbox, your body never gets its evening — everyone who has finally taken a genuinely offline weekend knows the difference in their chest. Half-off is not off.

#153 — Day 9 (content)

OLD: Presenteeism — being physically or digitally present and available for work considerably beyond what's actually productive or necessary, sometimes at the direct cost of health, sleep, or genuine effectiveness — deserves specific attention, because it's often mistaken for dedication or high performance when the actual research on productivity and overwork suggests something more complicated and, in many cases, counterproductive.

NEW: Presenteeism — being present and available far past the point of anything useful, at the direct cost of health and sleep — deserves specific attention, because it gets mistaken for dedication when it's mostly just visible exhaustion.

#154 — Day 9 (content)

OLD: A substantial body of research on working hours and productivity has found that output doesn't scale linearly with hours worked past a certain point, and in fact tends to decline measurably beyond roughly fifty hours per

week for many types of knowledge work, with productivity per hour dropping enough that total weekly output can actually be lower for someone working significantly longer hours compared to someone working a more moderate, sustainable schedule, due to accumulated fatigue, reduced focus, and more errors requiring correction.

NEW: Every honest worker already knows what hour eleven produces. Past a point, more hours make worse work — the fatigue stacks, the focus thins, the mistakes multiply, until the long week actually yields less than a sane one would have. You've watched it happen at your own desk.

#155 — Day 9 (content)

OLD: Presenteeism culture — where visible, extended presence is rewarded or expected regardless of actual output — also tends to punish more efficient, boundaried work styles, creating organizational pressure that can make personal boundary-setting feel professionally risky even when the underlying research suggests boundaried, well-rested work tends to be more genuinely productive over any sustained period.

NEW: Presenteeism culture — where visible hours are rewarded regardless of output — punishes efficient, boundaried work, which is what makes boundary-setting feel professionally risky even when the boundaried worker is plainly delivering more.

#156 — Day 10 (content)

OLD: Today marks a shift toward concrete, structural action, because — as with every compulsive behavior covered across this broader recovery program — understanding the psychology and research intellectually rarely produces lasting change on its own, and structural boundaries change the equation by reducing the number of moments where compulsive overwork is the easy, automatic default, rather than relying on willpower alone in a culture and technological environment that makes constant availability effortlessly possible.

NEW: Today marks a shift toward concrete, structural action, because — as with every pattern in this program — understanding it intellectually rarely changes it. Structure changes it: fewer moments where overwork is the automatic default, less reliance on willpower in a world built for constant availability.

Other

#163 — Day 2 (content)

OLD: Regardless of the specific content of a compulsive behavior — whether it involves a substance, a screen, an object, a physical action, or a relationship pattern — the underlying neurological mechanisms that make it feel so difficult to control are remarkably consistent, and understanding them can be genuinely relieving, because it reframes the struggle away from personal weakness and toward an accurate picture of how reward and habit circuitry actually works in every human brain.

NEW: Regardless of what your particular behavior is — a substance, a screen, an object, a physical action, or a relationship pattern — the engine underneath is remarkably consistent, and seeing that clearly is genuinely relieving, because it reframes the struggle away from personal weakness and toward how habit actually works in every human being.

#164 — Day 2 (content)

OLD: Nearly every compulsive behavior activates the brain's dopamine-driven reward and motivation system, which evolved to reinforce behaviors that once reliably supported survival — eating, social bonding, avoiding danger — but which can be activated just as powerfully by behaviors that provide none of those original survival benefits, simply because they trigger the same underlying reward circuitry through more direct, concentrated means.

NEW: Nearly every compulsive behavior runs on the same chase — machinery built to reward eating, bonding, and survival, hijacked by something that delivers the buzz more directly and gives none of the original benefit back.

#165 — Day 2 (content)

OLD: A key concept worth understanding is the difference between wanting and liking, a distinction well established in addiction neuroscience: over time, with repetition, a compulsive behavior can generate an intense drive or craving to engage in it — the wanting — even as the actual satisfaction or pleasure it provides in the moment — the liking — genuinely decreases, which explains a pattern many people with compulsive behaviors of any kind describe: continuing to feel a powerful pull toward the behavior even when they've stopped genuinely enjoying it, sometimes even actively dreading it while still feeling unable to resist the urge.

NEW: A key concept worth understanding is the difference between wanting and liking — and anyone with a long-running pattern knows it from the inside: over time the pull gets stronger while the payoff gets weaker, until you're chasing hard something you don't even enjoy anymore, sometimes dreading it mid-reach and reaching anyway.

#166 — Day 2 (content)

OLD: None of this means you're uniquely weak-willed or broken — it means you're a human brain responding, in a very normal and predictable way, to a behavior that's been repeated enough times to build genuine neurological momentum.

NEW: None of this means you're uniquely weak-willed or broken — it means you're a human being responding the way humans predictably respond to anything repeated often enough to build real momentum.

#168 — Day 7 (content)

OLD: Over these six days you've begun looking clearly and specifically at your own compulsive behavior, understood the underlying neurological mechanisms — the wanting-versus-liking distinction, the shift toward automatic habit — that make it feel so difficult to control through willpower alone, explored the emotional function the behavior has been serving for you, understood the full trigger-behavior-relief-shame cycle and the multiple points where intervention becomes possible, honestly accounted for the real cost of the pattern and considered whether specialized professional support might be warranted for your specific situation, and started mapping your own specific trigger pattern in detail.

NEW: Over these six days you've begun looking clearly and specifically at your own compulsive behavior, seen the engine underneath — wanting more while enjoying less, the slide into autopilot — that makes willpower alone such a losing strategy, explored the emotional function the behavior has been serving for you, understood the full trigger-behavior-relief-shame cycle and the multiple points where intervention becomes possible, honestly accounted for the real cost of the pattern and considered whether specialized professional support might be warranted for your specific situation, and started mapping your own specific trigger pattern in detail.

#169 — Day 9 (content)

OLD: It's worth understanding why sustainable, gradual change tends to work better than dramatic, willpower-based elimination for most compulsive behaviors: gradual change allows you to build and test structural supports and alternative coping strategies incrementally, gathering real evidence about what actually helps for your specific pattern, rather than betting everything on willpower alone holding indefinitely against a well-established, neurologically reinforced habit.

NEW: It's worth understanding why gradual change beats dramatic elimination for most people: gradual change lets you build and test supports one at a time, gathering real evidence about what works for your pattern, instead of betting everything on willpower holding forever against a habit with years of momentum behind it.

#173 — Day 12 (content)

OLD: This isn't about minimizing the seriousness of your struggle or pretending it away with positive self-talk — it's about replacing an inaccurate, harshly moralized story with a more accurate, useful one, grounded in the actual neuroscience and psychology of compulsive behavior covered throughout this program, which consistently shows that these patterns, however deeply established, remain genuinely changeable with the right combination of understanding, structural support, and sustained effort.

NEW: This isn't about minimizing the seriousness of your struggle or papering over it with positive self-talk — it's about replacing a harsh, moralized story with an accurate one: patterns like this, however deep, genuinely change with the right mix of understanding, structure, and sustained effort.

#174 — Day 16 (content)

OLD: The good news, consistent with every other category throughout this broader recovery framework, is that reward and dopamine-related circuitry respond to a genuinely wide range of experiences, many of which offer more durable, less costly satisfaction than a compulsive behavior tends to provide over time.

NEW: The good news, consistent with every other category in this framework, is that the lift the behavior provided is available from a genuinely wide range of experiences — most of them more durable, and all of them less costly.

#175 — Day 16 (content)

OLD: It's worth being honest that none of these alternatives will feel as immediately, viscerally compelling as your established behavior in the first weeks of change — your reward sensitivity has likely been calibrated, to some degree, by sustained engagement with a well-established, neurologically reinforced pattern, and recalibrating toward finding slower, more effortful rewards genuinely satisfying again typically takes real time, usually weeks rather than days.

NEW: It's worth being honest that none of these alternatives will hit as hard as your established behavior in the first weeks — a long-running pattern resets what 'satisfying' feels like, and the slower, realer rewards take weeks, not days, to start landing again. They do land again — everyone who has stayed the course says the same thing.

#177 — Day 18 (content)

OLD: If your behavior involves repetitive body-focused actions like hair-pulling or skin-picking that have continued despite genuine effort to stop, evidence-based treatments like habit reversal training, delivered by a therapist trained specifically in this approach, have strong research support and may accelerate your progress considerably beyond what a general program can offer alone.

NEW: If your behavior involves repetitive body-focused actions like hair-pulling or skin-picking that have continued despite genuine effort to stop, there are treatments built specifically for it — habit reversal training, delivered by a therapist trained in that approach — and people who've struggled for years often move faster with those than any general program can offer alone.

#180 — Day 20 (content)

OLD: Consider your physical environment: is there a specific location, room, or setting most strongly associated with the behavior, in the way certain physical environments become deeply conditioned triggers through repeated association, a well-documented phenomenon in addiction research generally.

NEW: Consider your physical environment: is there a specific location, room, or setting most strongly tied to the behavior? Places learn your patterns — anyone in recovery can name the room that still pulls at them.

#183 — Day 27 (content)

OLD: As acute early-recovery vigilance naturally softens over time, a specific and common relapse pathway deserves direct attention across nearly every form of compulsive behavior: the reintroduction of the behavior under the guise of a bounded, reasonable exception — 'just this once, given how stressful today has been,' or 'just a little, I've clearly got more control now than I used to.' This deserves honest, careful scrutiny, because as covered throughout this program, even a small, seemingly bounded return to a well-established compulsive pattern can reactivate the full cycle — the tension, the automatic pull, the shame discussed on Day 4 — considerably more completely than the 'just this once' framing would predict, precisely because the underlying neurological and behavioral pathways built over a long period of engaging in the behavior don't fully disappear during a period of reduced or eliminated engagement — they remain available to be reactivated by renewed exposure to the behavior itself.

NEW: As acute early-recovery vigilance naturally softens over time, one relapse pathway deserves direct attention across nearly every form of compulsive behavior: the return of the behavior dressed up as a bounded, reasonable exception — 'just this once, given today,' or 'just a little, I clearly have more control now.' Look at that one hard, because even a small, 'bounded' return to a well-established pattern can wake the full cycle — the tension, the automatic pull, the shame from Day 4 — far more completely than 'just this once' predicts. The groove you spent years wearing doesn't vanish while you're away from it. It waits for the cue.

Supporting Someone

#184 — Day 16 (content)

OLD: It rewires your baseline.

NEW: It resets your baseline.

Anger & Control

#186 — Day 3 (content)

OLD: When the threat signal fires, your body dumps adrenaline: heart rate up, blood to the big muscles, jaw and fists tight, hearing narrows, vision tunnels.

NEW: When the switch flips, your body takes over: heart rate up, jaw and fists tight, hearing narrows, vision tunnels.

#188 — Day 13 (content)

OLD: This has been demonstrated over and over in a lab, and you've demonstrated it yourself, repeatedly, on a Tuesday.

NEW: You've proven it on yourself a hundred Tuesdays in a row: short sleep, short fuse.

KEEPS (62)

Porn & Sex

- #7 d5 [VERB] "Research one recovery community, support group, or therapist specializing in compulsive sexual behavior."
- #9 d26 [VERB] "If you don't currently have a therapist and think you might benefit from one, research one specialist or clini..."

Alcohol

- #14 d5 [VERB] "Pick one concrete step: research a support group meeting near you (many now offer virtual options), tell one t..."
- #15 d5 [VERB] "Research one specific support option today — an AA or SMART Recovery meeting, a therapist specializing in alco..."
- #20 d25 [VERB] "Reach out to your accountability contact today, or if you don't have one yet, take one concrete step — researc..."
- #21 d26 [VERB] "If you have any signs of physical dependency or have struggled with repeated attempts to quit, research one me..."
- #22 d27 [VERB] "Research one specific alcohol recovery community today — an AA or SMART Recovery meeting near you, or an onlin..."

Smoking

- #28 d16 [VERB] "If you haven't already, research nicotine replacement options or talk to a pharmacist or doctor about what mig..."
- #31 d25 [VERB] "Reach out to your accountability contact today, or if you don't have one yet, research a smoking quitline in y..."
- #33 d26 [VERB] "If previous quit attempts haven't held, research one professional resource today — a doctor, quitline, or cess..."
- #34 d30 [ENGLISH] "Keep going, not to prove something to anyone, but because the years of health ahead are genuinely worth what t..."

Substances

- #35 d3 [VERB + SAFETY (naloxone access)] "If relevant to your situation, research where to access naloxone in your area today, even if you don't anticip..."
- #36 d5 [VERB] "Research your specific options carefully, but don't let fear of consequences be the sole reason you avoid supp..."
- #37 d5 [VERB] "Research one specific support option today — an NA or SMART Recovery meeting, an addiction medicine doctor, or..."
- #38 d6 [VERB + SAFETY (safe disposal)] "If disposal needs to be done safely — particularly for prescription medications or needles — many pharmacies a..."
- #39 d9 [VERB] "Consider researching a trauma-informed therapist this week."
- #43 d15 [VERB] "Research the general recovery timeline for the specific substance(s) you've used, and note where you might rea..."
- #46 d16 [VERB + SAFETY (MAT referral)] "If relevant to your substance use, research medication-assisted treatment options today and consider discussin..."
- #47 d18 [VERB] "If you have legal or significant financial consequences to address, identify one concrete next step you can ta..."
- #48 d25 [VERB] "Reach out to your accountability contact today, or if you don't have one yet, take one concrete step — researc..."
- #49 d26 [VERB] "If you have any dependency risk, repeated unsuccessful attempts, or significant harm from use, research one me..."
- #50 d27 [VERB] "Research one specific substance recovery community today — an NA or SMART Recovery meeting near you, or an onl..."

Gambling

- #63 d19 [VERB] "Research one gambling-specific financial counseling resource in your country or state today (the National Coun..."

Social media

- #95 d26 [ENGLISH (self-evidence, no science claim)] "Other interventions might reasonably loosen over time as you build genuine confidence in your own capacity for..."

Gaming

- #97 d1 [FACT (industry practice, no health claim)] "Modern games, particularly free-to-play and live-service titles, are also genuinely different from games of a ..."
- #104 d15 [ENGLISH (a question, no claim)] "Has gaming during hours meant for school or work — checking a phone-based game during class or meetings, or mo..."
- #105 d17 [ENGLISH (evidence of income, not science)] "This isn't to say professional gaming or content creation is never a legitimate path — it genuinely is for a s..."

- #107 d18 [ENGLISH] "As with trust repair in any addiction recovery context, this tends to happen gradually, through consistent dem..."
- #108 d26 [ENGLISH (proven difficult for you personally)] "This isn't true for everyone, and it's worth being honest about which category you fall into: if gaming has ca..."
- #109 d26 [ENGLISH (proven most effective for you)] "Maintaining the structural barriers that have proven most effective — time limits, payment method restrictions..."
- #110 d26 [ENGLISH] "Choosing games and genres deliberately, with real awareness of which specific mechanics (loot boxes, battle pa..."
- #112 d28 [ENGLISH] "Consider, too, what kind of achievement you actually want to be building toward over the coming months and yea..."

Food / Binging

- #113 d1 [SAFETY (eating disorder triage — must stay clinical)] "It is not a substitute for specialized treatment if you're experiencing restrictive eating, significant and ra..."
- #114 d3 [FACT (documented food-industry practice)] "A significant portion of the modern food supply, particularly heavily processed and packaged foods, is engine..."
- #115 d3 [FACT (journalism sourcing for the previous point)] "This isn't speculation; it's documented industry practice, described in detail by food scientists and journali..."
- #119 d7 [SAFETY (recap includes ED triage distinction)] "Over these six days you've begun looking honestly and non-judgmentally at your own eating patterns, learned an..."
- #126 d21 [SAFETY] "You've built an important, potentially life-protecting understanding of the distinction between compulsive ove..."
- #127 d23 [SAFETY (medical monitoring context)] "If you're currently working with a doctor, it's worth being honest with them about your eating patterns specif..."
- #128 d23 [VERB] "Research one specific support resource today — a therapist specializing in binge eating or compulsive overeati..."
- #129 d30 [SAFETY] "You've built an important, potentially protective understanding of the distinction between compulsive overeati..."

Shopping / Spending

- #138 d11 [ENGLISH] "This can be discouraging to hear, especially if you're hoping for quick forgiveness and a fresh start, but und..."
- #141 d16 [VERB (researching a topic of interest)] "Activities with a genuine anticipation-and-payoff structure that doesn't involve spending can meet some of the..."
- #142 d16 [VERB] "For the specific 'hunt' or searching dynamic discussed on Day 2, it's worth considering whether that need for ..."
- #144 d19 [VERB] "If you haven't already, research one specific financial counseling resource this week — a nonprofit credit cou..."

Work

- #157 d11 [ENGLISH (demonstrated boundary-setting)] "If your work pattern has caused real strain, an honest, non-defensive conversation about its actual impact — n..."
- #158 d12 [VERB (vacation research/planning)] "Do you find yourself unconsciously turning leisure activities into a form of productivity or achievement (trac..."
- #159 d18 [SAFETY (depression/self-harm referral)] "If burnout has progressed to include significant depression, persistent hopelessness, or any thoughts of self-..."

- #160 d19 [ENGLISH] "Trust and connection eroded by a long pattern of overwork-driven absence, similar to trust repair covered in o..."
- #161 d19 [ENGLISH] "This can be genuinely difficult to accept if you're hoping that setting a few new boundaries will quickly repa..."
- #162 d19 [ENGLISH] "What matters most is genuine, sustained, demonstrated change in priority and presence going forward, communica..."

Other

- #167 d5 [VERB] "Separately, honestly consider whether your specific pattern might benefit from specialized professional suppor..."
- #170 d11 [ENGLISH] "Trust affected by a compulsive pattern, whether through direct harm, secrecy, or simply diminished presence an..."
- #171 d11 [ENGLISH] "This can be discouraging to hear if you're hoping for a quicker resolution, but understanding it accurately ac..."
- #172 d11 [ENGLISH] "If appropriate and safe, offer one concrete piece of honest disclosure or demonstrated follow-through to someo..."
- #176 d18 [SAFETY (specialized treatment referral)] "Some compulsive behaviors, while genuinely benefiting from the general recovery principles covered throughout ..."
- #178 d18 [SAFETY] "Honestly reassess, now partway through this program, whether your specific behavior might benefit from special..."
- #179 d18 [VERB] "If so, research one specific type of specialized therapist or treatment approach today."
- #181 d23 [VERB] "Research one specific support resource today — a therapist experienced with your particular type of behavior, ..."
- #182 d26 [ENGLISH] "The core principles worth carrying forward permanently, rather than treating as temporary interventions to be ..."

Supporting Someone

- #185 d24 [VERB] "You've probably researched treatment centers they never called."

Anger & Control

- #187 d5 [ENGLISH] "Which proves something you may not want proven: you have control."
- #189 d26 [ENGLISH] "Not apologies — safety, demonstrated, repeatedly, especially when it's inconvenient."

SUPPLEMENTARY — 4 sentences the keyword list missed (found by hand, same treatment proposed)

Porn & Sex, Day 1 (content)

OLD: That crash isn't a moral failing either. It's the chemical comedown, and it's temporary, even when it doesn't feel that way at 2am.

NEW: That crash isn't a moral failing either. It's the comedown, and it's temporary, even when it doesn't feel that way at 2am.

Anger & Control, Day 3 (content)

OLD: Critically, blood flow to the front of your brain — the part that weighs consequences and finds words — drops. That's not a metaphor. At full flood you are, briefly, running on older hardware.

NEW: And the thinking part of you — the part that weighs consequences and finds words — goes partially offline. You've felt it: at full flood you genuinely cannot find the careful version of the sentence. You're running on older hardware.

Anger & Control, Day 3 (content)

OLD: When the threat signal fires, your body dumps adrenaline: heart rate up, blood to the big muscles, jaw and fists tight, hearing narrows, vision tunnels.

NEW: (covered as #186 above)

Anger & Control, Day 13 (content)

OLD: One night of short sleep measurably reduces the connection between the emotional alarm in your brain and the part that regulates it. Under-slept people react harder to small provocations and take longer to come down.

NEW: One short night takes a visible chunk off your patience — anyone who has worked a double or parented a newborn already knows. Under-slept people snap harder at smaller things and take longer to come down.

PIPELINE WARNING (must fix as part of this task)

`data/build-lessons.js` regenerates `lessons.json` from the 11 source files in `data/lessons/`.

The Supporting Someone and Anger & Control tracks exist ONLY in `lessons.json` — if that script is ever run today, BOTH NEW TRACKS ARE DELETED. As part of applying this audit I will:

1. Split the two new tracks into `lessons/lesson12.json` and `lessons/lesson13.json`
2. Set `PACK_COUNT` to 13
3. Apply every approved rewrite to the SOURCE files, then regenerate `lessons.json` with the script

That makes the pipeline safe and puts the rewrites in both places at once.

HOW IT SHIPS (after your approval)

- Apply rewrites to source files → run `build-lessons.js` → verify `lessons.json` has 13 packs x 30 days and zero remaining claim phrases → bump service worker so phones refetch lesson content → partner + anger regression tests → commit and push.
- Out of scope, noted for a future task: the Withdrawal Timeline screen in `index.html` contains medical-adjacent content ("brain chemistry rebalancing", seizure-risk warnings). The seizure warnings should STAY (safety), but the timeline was not part of Task 4's file list, so I touched nothing there.